army and the country's main economic resources, but it lacks popular appeal. Every time the generals have allowed a relatively open election, they have gained very few votes. A practical problem is that they too are reliant on the Buddhist hierarchy if they wish to shore up their economic and military power with some degree of popular appeal. Equally, as with the NLD, they have little or no popular support outside the Burman ethnic group. However, it is now clear that they are using the extremists in the MaBaTha in an attempt to channel popular support away from the NLD and towards the USDP.

Third, the two main parties have effectively become Burman ethnic parties. In most ethnically-dominated areas of Myanmar local groups have their own electoral vehicles, whatever level of discrimination they face. In Rakhine, the ethnically Rakhine, who are also all Buddhist, have followed this pattern and this creates a basis of support for the RNDP/ANP. One threat to the RNDP's electoral dominance there has come from the splits within the Rakhine political elite over the share of the spoils.[2] There is one ethnic group in Myanmar not only lacking its own political party but, due to all the changes put in place for the 2015 elections, now completely denied both the vote and the possibility of members of its community being elected as part of the other political parties.[3] For the first time since independence, the parliament in Myanmar has no Muslim members, from any ethnic group.

Practical politics in Rakhine has been reduced to the dispute between the RNDP and ANP, with the NLD[4] and the USDP seeking to gain their own electoral base in the province. In fighting for the votes of the Buddhist Rakhine community, none of these parties will gain if they publicly moderate their views about the Rohingyas.[5] The result is that none will do so: having rigged the electoral system to exclude the Rohingyas, all the parties can compete about is being most likely to be the most brutal.

Fourth, this leads on to a consideration of the nature of Buddhism in Myanmar. Since the 1990s, the monks, monasteries and religious schools have become increasingly important in the lives of many Burmese. They provide a social security network and offer education for those unable to afford formal schooling. This, combined with their role in the 1988 and 2007 uprisings, has given the monks a great deal of moral authority. It also meant that as a political force they were able to act as the link between the NLD, with its elite and student base, and the mass of Burmese people.